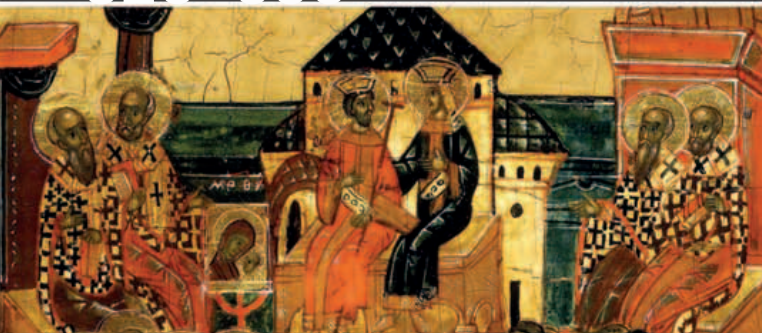




It was largely Eastern Church leaders who gathered at the Council of Nicaea (depicted here) in 325; only eight Western bishops made the journey there.

CHANDRAGUPTA I ASCENDED TO THE THRONE of a small kingdom in the western Ganges Plain in 320. Through an **advantageous marriage** to Princess Kumaradevi of the powerful Licchachevi dynasty and by conquest, he **expanded his realm** to include most of the central Ganges, from Magadha (in southern Bihar) to Prayaga (in Uttar Pradesh). His descendants, the Guptas, ruled northern India for almost 150 years.



The Column of Constantine
The sole surviving monument from the forum that Constantine built for his new city is this column, which sits in central Istanbul today.

Having taken up the **cause of Christianity** in 313, the Roman Emperor Constantine (r. 280–337) found that Christians themselves were far from united in **doctrine or organization**. Constantine called a church **council at Nicaea** in western Asia Minor in 325 to establish (and impose) orthodoxy in the face of a division over **Arianism** (the theology of Arius, who held that Jesus Christ was subordinate to God the Father). As well as Constantine, about 300 church leaders attended, and Arius's views were condemned.

14

THE NUMBER OF DISTRICTS IN CONSTANTINOPLE

After **defeating Licinius** (r. 308–24) in 324, Constantine **founded a new capital** for the Eastern Roman Empire at the ancient city of **Byzantium**, strategically sited between Europe and Asia. He demolished pagan temples and built new churches, such as Hagia Sophia, providing public buildings to rival those of Rome. The city of **Constantinople** (modern Istanbul) was publicly dedicated on April 2, 330. It was the seat of the Eastern Emperors for over 1,000 years.

“ IN OTHER MEN... TASTE FOR SLAUGHTER SOMETIMES LOSES ITS FORCE... IN CONSTANTINUS IT BECAME MORE VIOLENT. ”

Ammianus Marcellinus (d. c. 330) writing on the character of the Emperor Constantius II in *The Later Roman Empire*

8

THE NUMBER OF TYPES OF PURE-GOLD COINS ISSUED BY SAMUDRAGUPTA

IN 335, SAMUDRAGUPTA (r. 335–75) **SUCCEEDED HIS FATHER** Chandragupta I as ruler of the Gupta domains in northern India. An inscription he set up in Prayaga survives, recounting a **series of campaigns** he fought in **Uttar Pradesh** and **Mathura**, both of which were annexed to the Gupta kingdom. He also made conquests down the east coast of India, as far as **Madras**, and subdued **West Bengal** as well as parts of **Rajasthan** and the **Punjab**. Various other regions acknowledged his suzerainty, making him the **most powerful Indian ruler** since the Mauryas.

Constantine died in 337, having accepted Christian baptism only on his deathbed. He had made no definite provision for **succession**, leaving his sons to divide the empire between them: **Constantine II** (r. 337–40) held Spain, Gaul, and Britain; **Constans** (r. 337–50) ruled Italy, and **Constantius II** (r. 337–61)

governed the Eastern Empire. Their reigns began with a **massacre at Constantinople** in which almost all of their father's other male relatives were killed in order to remove any possible rivals. Constantine II, who was the eldest, tried to assert his seniority, but **died during an invasion of Italy** in 340. Constans then took control of the entire Western Empire, where he was faced with a series of hard-fought campaigns against **Frankish invaders in Gaul**, and problems in **Britain**, which led him to visit the far-flung province (the last undisputed Roman Emperor to do so) in 343.

Disputes between the two surviving brothers, particularly one over the status of **Athanasius, Bishop of Alexandria** (whom Constantius II had exiled, but Constans wanted restored), soured all relations between them. In 350, a senior military officer, **Magnentius**, revolted at



Gold Gupta coin
Many Gupta coins contain images of horses, a possible reference to the ritual horse sacrifice performed by some Gupta rulers.

Augustodunum in southern Gaul (modern Autun, France) and **Constans was killed**. Distracted by a war against Persia, Constantius II tolerated the upstart initially, but in 351 he moved against him. Since Constantius II had no heir, he promoted his cousin **Gallus**—one of the few survivors of the massacre of 337—to the rank of Caesar in 351 and left him **in charge in the East**, while he campaigned against Magnentius in the West. Magnentius's army was **defeated at Mursa** (in present-day Croatia); Italy and North Africa were rapidly recovered, and in 353 **Magnentius committed suicide** in Gaul.

For the next seven years **Constantius II ruled the empire alone**, mainly preoccupied with Frankish incursions into Gaul, the revolt of the usurper Silvanus in 355, and a **series of church councils** that sought to resolve doctrinal disputes (Constantius II favored Arianism over the traditional orthodoxy).

In the end, Gallus proved too ambitious and in 354 he was **deposed and executed**. Constantius II turned instead to Gallus's brother **Julian**, a studious youth with a penchant for pagan philosophy. In 355, after Silvanus's revolt, **Julian was despatched to Gaul** as Caesar, where he proved surprisingly effective at combating Frankish raiders.

